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Scott Wiener Comes Clean

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Scott Wiener is a California State Senator who represents the city of San Francisco. During his years in the legislature, he has earned a reputation as a tireless and effective (if sometimes condescending) policy wonk who has been one of the Capitol's driving forces in confronting issues such as affordable housing, clean energy and artificial intelligence over the years. Even his critics agree that he is extremely intelligent, masterful on policy details and relentless in pursuit of common ground and tangible outcomes. He has also been the co-chair of the Jewish Legislative Caucus, where he has been a supporter of Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel's (D-Encino) efforts in the fight against antisemitism.

Wiener is now running for Congress, pursuing the seat of retiring House Speaker Nancy Pelosi. While Wiener is aggressively and proudly progressive, he is in a race against two candidates to the left of him on many issues. One of the issues on which he has been outflanked is Israel. Or at least it used to be.

In early January, Wiener participated in a debate in which the candidates were asked whether they believed that Israel was guilty of genocide in Gaza and told to hold up a sign saying either "yes" or "no". His opponents both held up their "yes" signs. Wiener, who had previously refused to use that incendiary term against the Jewish state, did not raise either sign and was met by a barrage of boos and cries of "shame" from the angry audience.

But only four days later, Wiener released a video reversing his position and stating he will now use the word "genocide" to criticize Israel's conduct. He explained that his previous hesitation stemmed from the painful connection of the term to the Holocaust for many Jews. He added, "But despite that pain … we all have eyes, and we see the absolute devastation and catastrophic death toll in Gaza ... that qualifies as genocide".

"We all have eyes." Very true. Wiener's eyes were open wide enough to read polls showing how much his previously-principled beliefs about Israel's defense against Hamas were harming his chances for victory. And our eyes can see how mortifying it is for a Jewish political climber to turn on his own people and their homeland and how ludicrous it is for him to continue to claim a position of legislative leadership.

So last week, Wiener resigned as Jewish Caucus co-chair, making official what most of us already knew: that he no longer deserved that honor. In a group of courageous Jewish legislators who work tirelessly every day on behalf of our community, he simply no longer belonged. He was not courageous. He was craven. He had become an embarrassment to the caucus – and to us.

If Wiener is elected to Congress, he may be more comfortable in an environment where many of his new colleagues regularly prioritize their own political ambition over the well-being of the communities they pretend to represent. Hopefully, the Congressional Jewish Caucus will have the dignity to refuse his admission into their ranks.

Or he might never get to Washington. Perhaps the left-leaning voters of San Francisco will see through his subterfuge, and they will elect a truly dedicated antizionist rather than a craven politician who merely pretends to oppose Israel for his own political benefit. Then he can spend the rest of his life wondering if selling out his people, his religion and his heritage in a futile bid for higher elective office was worth the humiliation it brought.

Let's be clear: Wiener has the right to take any political position he chooses. That is his prerogative and he has not broken any laws by simply changing his mind. But he no longer deserves to represent us, in elective office or in any other way.

Good riddance, Scott Wiener. For prioritizing your own political ambition over the safety and security of your own

community, you will become a reminder to all of us why we fight every day for our principles, our history and our future — and why self-haters like you have made that battle so much more challenging.

Dan Schnur is the U.S. Politics Editor for the Jewish Journal. He teaches courses in politics, communications, and leadership at UC Berkeley, USC and Pepperdine. He hosts the monthly webinar "The Dan Schnur Political Report" for the Los Angeles World Affairs Council & Town Hall. Follow Dan's work at www.danschnurpolitics.com.

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